

The meeting, scene by scene

Group role-play script — Investec IT support team, monthly technical practitioners meeting

Time: 90 minutes (10 min preparation · 60 min meeting · 20 min debrief) · Activity: Whole group — all 12 learners, one role each · Venue: training room arranged as a boardroom · Assessment: the facilitator observes against SO1–SO4.

The class is the Investec IT support team. Today is the team's monthly technical practitioners meeting — a combined technical review and project review meeting. The big item on the agenda: a proposal to upgrade the training-room network — replacing the old 100 Mbps switch with a 24-port gigabit switch and adding a second wireless access point — on a quotation of R18 500 from NetSupplies.

Every learner is assigned ONE role below and must role-play it fully — say the words and perform the actions. The meeting runs through the complete agenda in this order:

THE CAST — 12 ROLES, ONE EACH

Role 1	Chairperson
Role 2	Vice-chairperson & preparation officer
Role 3	Secretary (minute-taker)
Role 4	Treasurer
Role 5	Senior technician (technical report)
Role 6	Mover of the motion
Role 7	Second
Role 8	Objector & amendment proposer
Role 9	Point of order & questions
Role 10	Scrutineer (voting officer)
Role 11	Matters arising & report-back
Role 12	Timekeeper & meeting evaluator

THE AGENDA — RUN IT IN THIS ORDER

1. Opening, welcome and introductions
2. Attendance and apologies
3. Confirmation of the agenda
4. Minutes of the previous meeting
5. Matters arising
6. Correspondence
7. Treasurer's report
8. Technical report
9. New business — the network upgrade motion
10. General
11. Date of next meeting and closing

GROUND RULES

Speak THROUGH THE CHAIR ("Chairperson, ..."), one speaker at a time, keep to your allocated time, accept the ruling of the chair, and respect the outcome of the vote. The script below plays the whole meeting out scene by scene, exactly in the order it runs — find your role's lines in each scene and deliver them in your own natural words, improvising realistic discussion around them. Download and print the role cards, cut them up, and let learners draw their roles.

SCENE 1 — BEFORE THE MEETING (08h45 · the boardroom)

(The VICE-CHAIRPERSON arrives first, checklist in hand — businesslike and brief: boardroom seating checked, projector and flip chart tested, spare agendas on the table.)

(Members take their seats. The SECRETARY opens the attendance register and starts writing — and keeps writing for the whole meeting. The TIMEKEEPER sits in the chairperson's line of sight, watch ready. The TREASURER lays out the figures on paper. The SENIOR TECHNICIAN pins the network diagram to the flip chart.)

SCENE 2 — OPENING, WELCOME & INTRODUCTIONS (09h00 · agenda item 1)

(The CHAIRPERSON sits at the head of the table — upright, calm and strictly neutral, making eye contact around the whole table.)

CHAIRPERSON: “Good morning, colleagues. I declare this monthly technical practitioners meeting of the Investec IT support team open at 09h00. As chairperson my role is to run the meeting according to the agenda, give every member a fair chance to speak, keep the discussion on the item at hand, and make sure every decision is clear and has a timeframe. This is a democratic meeting — decisions are taken by majority vote. Before our first item, let’s go around the table: please introduce yourself, your role, and what your role does. I will start.”

CHAIRPERSON: “I am [your name], the chairperson. I run the meeting — I follow the agenda, give members the floor, keep order, and make sure every decision is clear, with a deadline and a responsible person.”

VICE-CHAIRPERSON: “I am [your name], the vice-chairperson and preparation officer. I make sure the meeting is properly set up — venue, equipment, documents and quorum — and I stand in for the chairperson when needed.”

SECRETARY: “I am [your name], the secretary and minute-taker. I record who is present, what is decided, who must do it and by when — and after the meeting I distribute the minutes to everyone.”

TREASURER: “I am [your name], the treasurer. I look after the money — I report what we have spent, what is left in the budget, and whether the proposals before us are affordable.”

SENIOR TECHNICIAN: “I am [your name], the senior technician. I present the technical report — the facts and measurements about our systems that this meeting needs to take informed decisions.”

MOVER (ROLE 6): “I am [your name], a member of the team. Today I will move a motion — I formally put the network upgrade proposal on the table for the meeting to debate and vote on.”

SECONDER (ROLE 7): “I am [your name], a member of the team. Today I will second the motion — the supporting voice a proposal must have before the meeting may debate it.”

OBJECTOR (ROLE 8): “I am [your name], a member of the team. My part today is to test the motion — I will raise an objection and propose an amendment, so that the meeting takes a better decision.”

ROLE 9: “I am [your name], a member of the team. I help protect our meeting rules — if procedure is broken I raise a point of order for the chairperson to rule on, and I ask my questions through the chair.”

SCRUTINEER (ROLE 10): “I am [your name], the scrutineer — the voting officer. When the meeting votes, I explain the method, count the votes and announce the result to the chairperson.”

ROLE 11: “I am [your name], a member of the team. I report back on the action items from our previous meeting, so this meeting can check that its decisions were actually carried out.”

TIMEKEEPER (ROLE 12): “I am [your name], the timekeeper and evaluator. I watch the clock on every agenda item, warn the chairperson when time is nearly up, and at the end I give short feedback on how well the meeting ran.”

SCENE 3 — ATTENDANCE, APOLOGIES & QUORUM (agenda item 2)

CHAIRPERSON: “Thank you, everyone. Secretary, do we have any apologies?”

SECRETARY: “Chairperson, one apology — the service manager is at a client site. Eleven members are present.”

VICE-CHAIRPERSON: “Chairperson, the boardroom was booked, the projector and flip chart are working, and the notice, agenda and supporting documents were e-mailed to all twelve members seven days ago, as required. Eleven members are present and one apology was received — we have a quorum, the meeting can proceed.”

CHAIRPERSON: “Thank you — the apology is accepted and we have a quorum. The meeting is properly constituted.”

SCENE 4 — CONFIRMATION OF THE AGENDA (agenda item 3)

CHAIRPERSON: “You all received the agenda seven days ago. Are there any additions under General? ... None. The agenda is confirmed as circulated.”

SCENE 5 — MINUTES OF THE PREVIOUS MEETING (agenda item 4)

CHAIRPERSON: “Secretary, please take us through the minutes of 7 August.”

SECRETARY: “The minutes of the meeting of 7 August: the meeting approved the new backup rotation; the printer-fleet audit was assigned to Role 11, due 30 August; the toner budget query was referred to the treasurer. Those are the minutes as recorded.”

SECRETARY: “Colleagues, note why the note taker must have a technical background — when you debate VLANs, port counts and access points, I must minute the decisions accurately, not guess at the terminology.”

CHAIRPERSON: “Is there a mover for the adoption of the minutes? ... Moved and seconded. I sign the minutes as a true record.”

SCENE 6 — MATTERS ARISING (agenda item 5)

(ROLE 11 reports back in the past tense, with facts — and hands the evidence to the secretary.)

CHAIRPERSON: “Matters arising from the minutes — the printer-fleet audit. Your report-back, please.”

ROLE 11: “Chairperson, reporting back on the printer-fleet audit assigned to me on 7 August: the audit is complete — fourteen printers checked, two need new toner rollers, and the full list has been handed to the secretary for the record.”

CHAIRPERSON: “Thank you — minuted as completed.”

SCENE 7 — CORRESPONDENCE (agenda item 6)

CHAIRPERSON: “Secretary, any correspondence?”

SECRETARY: “One letter received — a quotation from NetSupplies: R18 500 for a 24-port gigabit switch and one access point, valid for 30 days.”

CHAIRPERSON: “Noted — the quotation will serve before us under new business.”

SCENE 8 — TREASURER'S REPORT · THE INTERRUPTION (agenda item 7)

(The TREASURER presents from figures on paper — slowly, factually, never guessing a number.)

CHAIRPERSON: “The next item is the treasurer's report — Treasurer, please take us through it.”

TREASURER: “Chairperson, the treasurer's report for August: opening balance R42 000; expenditure — R6 200 on toner and R3 800 on cabling and connectors; closing balance R32 000. The equipment budget for this quarter still has R25 000 unspent. I move that the financial report be accepted.”

(ROLE 11 leans over and speaks DIRECTLY to the treasurer, out of turn — staged, by arrangement with ROLE 9.)

ROLE 11: “And another thing, Treasurer — next month we must also talk about laptop bags and...”

ROLE 9: “POINT OF ORDER, Chairperson — the member is addressing the treasurer directly and discussing next month's business. Members must speak through the chair and keep to the item under discussion.”

CHAIRPERSON: “The point of order is upheld. Please speak through the chair, and hold new items for General.”

ROLE 11: “Apologies, Chairperson — I withdraw, and will raise it under General.”

CHAIRPERSON: “The financial report has been moved for acceptance — seconded? ... The report is accepted.”

SCENE 9 — TECHNICAL REPORT (agenda item 8)

(The SENIOR TECHNICIAN presents standing at the flip chart — numbers, not adjectives, and never defensive under questioning.)

CHAIRPERSON: “Senior technician, your technical report, please.”

SENIOR TECHNICIAN: “Chairperson, my technical report. Over the past month the training-room network dropped twelve times during practical lessons. The current switch is a ten-year-old 100-megabit model running at 96% port capacity, and the single access point is serving 25 devices — double its design load. Lesson image downloads currently take 40 minutes; on a gigabit switch they would take under five. My recommendation to this meeting: replace the switch with a 24-port gigabit switch and add a second access point.”

CHAIRPERSON: “Thank you. Questions will be taken under new business, where the upgrade proposal serves.”

SCENE 10 — NEW BUSINESS · THE MOTION (agenda item 9)

(The MOVER waits for the floor, states the motion in ONE clear sentence — cost and deadline — then stops. The SECRETARY must be able to minute it word for word.)

CHAIRPERSON: “New business: the proposed upgrade of the training-room network. The floor goes to the mover.”

MOVER (ROLE 6): “Chairperson, in the light of the technical report I MOVE THAT the company purchases the 24-port gigabit switch and the additional access point on the NetSupplies quotation of R18 500, and that the upgrade be installed and tested by 30 September. Speaking to my motion: the downtime is costing us training hours every single week — this is the cheapest reliable fix.”

(The SECONDER comes in immediately — quick and confident, adding a NEW reason, not repeating the mover. A motion without a seconder dies on the spot.)

SECONDER (ROLE 7): “Chairperson, I SECOND the motion. Speaking in support: last Thursday the whole class lost twenty minutes of a practical because the network dropped. Twelve learners' lost time every week is worth far more than the price of one switch.”

CHAIRPERSON: “The motion has been moved and seconded. The floor is open for debate — through the chair, please.”

SCENE 11 — THE DEBATE

TREASURER: “Chairperson, to assist the meeting: the R18 500 quotation fits within the remaining equipment budget of R25 000 — but it would leave only R6 500 for the rest of the quarter, so nothing else major can be bought.”

ROLE 9: “Chairperson, through you: can the senior technician confirm that the new switch works with our existing cabling, or is there a hidden cost?”

SENIOR TECHNICIAN: “Through you, Chairperson: yes — our existing Cat5e cabling supports gigabit, so there is no hidden cabling cost.”

(The TIMEKEEPER catches the chairperson's eye with a quiet hand signal — never interrupting a speaker mid-sentence.)

TIMEKEEPER (ROLE 12): "Chairperson, time check — two minutes left on this item."

VICE-CHAIRPERSON: "Chairperson, may I suggest we allow five more minutes on this item and then move to the vote, so that we keep to the agenda times."

CHAIRPERSON: "Agreed — five more minutes on this item."

SCENE 12 — OBJECTION & AMENDMENT

(The OBJECTOR stays calm and respectful — attacks the wording and the plan, never the person, and offers the solution, not just the criticism.)

OBJECTOR (ROLE 8): "Chairperson, I OBJECT to the motion in its current form. My concern is operational, not financial: installing the switch during the week will take the training room offline in the middle of the timetable."

OBJECTOR (ROLE 8): "Chairperson, I PROPOSE AN AMENDMENT: that the words 'installed and tested by 30 September' be replaced with 'installed on a Saturday and tested before 30 September'. If the mover accepts, I will support the motion."

MOVER (ROLE 6): "Chairperson, I accept the amendment — the motion now reads that installation takes place on a Saturday and testing is complete before 30 September."

CHAIRPERSON: "If there is no further discussion, I put the amended motion to the vote — Scrutineer, please proceed."

SCENE 13 — THE VOTE

(The SCRUTINEER is absolutely impartial — the method is explained BEFORE the vote so nobody can dispute it afterwards.)

SCRUTINEER (ROLE 10): "Chairperson, colleagues — we decide by a show of hands, a simple majority of members present. You may vote FOR, AGAINST, or ABSTAIN. If the vote is tied, the chairperson has the casting vote. Alternatives such as consensus or ranking are available to a meeting, but today the notice specified a vote. As scrutineer I will count and announce the result."

(Hands go up — for, against, abstentions. The scrutineer counts every round TWICE and keeps a written note for the minutes.)

SCRUTINEER (ROLE 10): "Chairperson, the result: eight in favour, three against, one abstention — the motion, as amended, is carried."

CHAIRPERSON: "The motion is carried by eight votes to three, with one abstention. Decision: the network upgrade is approved, installation on a Saturday, tested before 30 September, the senior technician responsible. Secretary, please minute that."

(The SECRETARY writes the decision word for word — owner, deadline and cost — before the meeting moves on.)

SCENE 14 — GENERAL (agenda item 10)

CHAIRPERSON: "Any items under General?"

ROLE 11: "Chairperson, I propose an item for the next agenda: a standby-duty roster for exam week."

CHAIRPERSON: "Noted for the next agenda. Anything further? ... None."

SCENE 15 — EVALUATION, NEXT MEETING & CLOSING (agenda item 11)

(The TIMEKEEPER evaluates the meeting, never personalities — praise for the process first, then ONE improvement.)

CHAIRPERSON: “Before we close — Timekeeper, your evaluation, please.”

TIMEKEEPER (ROLE 12): “Chairperson, the meeting ran 65 minutes against the planned 60. The agenda was followed in order, every member spoke, the objection and the amendment were handled through the chair, and the final decision was clear, with a deadline and a responsible person. One improvement for next month: the technical report ran four minutes over — distributing the slides beforehand would save that time.”

SECRETARY: “I will circulate the minutes and the action list to all members by e-mail within 48 hours, in the company minute template.”

CHAIRPERSON: “Thank you all. The next meeting is on the first Friday of next month, 09h00, in this boardroom. I declare the meeting closed at 10h05.”

SCENE 16 — THE DEBRIEF (20 minutes · out of role, facilitator leads)

Why the chair matters: a meeting without a firm, neutral chair collapses into a chat — the chair's neutrality is what makes the vote legitimate, and the casting vote exists only to break a tie so the meeting cannot deadlock.

Why preparation matters: a meeting is won or lost before it starts — venue, equipment, documents in good time and a quorum are what make the decisions valid.

Why the minutes matter: the minutes are the legal memory of the meeting — if it is not minuted, it did not happen; and a note taker with a technical background minutes VLANs and port counts accurately instead of guessing.

Why the treasurer matters: the meeting can only take a responsible decision when it knows exactly what is affordable — the figures turn opinions into an informed vote.

Why the technical report matters: technical review meetings exist so that decisions rest on evidence — measured facts can be evaluated, vague complaints cannot.

Why moving a motion matters: a meeting can only vote on precise words — an exact cost and timeframe turn an idea into an enforceable, auditable decision.

Why seconding matters: it proves at least two members believe the idea deserves the meeting's time — it filters out one-person hobby-horses.

Why objection and amendment matter: healthy meetings NEED disagreement — the amendment procedure improves a motion instead of killing it, and attacking issues rather than people preserves the trust a technical team runs on.

Why the point of order matters: conventions only survive if someone defends them — speaking through the chair keeps ONE conversation happening instead of five; a point of order is the meeting's immune system.

Why the scrutineer matters: people accept losing a vote only when they trust the count — exact numbers (8–3–1) make the decision auditable; and voting is not the only tool: consensus, criteria-based rating, ranking and paired comparisons all have their place.

Why report-backs matter: matters arising closes the follow-up loop — without report-backs, action lists rot between meetings.

Why timekeeping and evaluation matter: twelve people's hour costs the company twelve working hours — and what gets measured gets better.